

What is medicine, if not an attempt to try and cheat nature. Chemotherapy, organ transplants, stem cell research, etc., are really just us playing “god” by trying to cheat death. We’re searching for the fountain of youth, and why not? Is there something wrong with people not wanting to die, or not wanting to suffer while they live?

MISUSE

Of course there is scope for misuse, and we will point to the rich and cry foul because, undoubtedly some rich person is going to pay to get his babies designed. It’s not like he or she isn’t already doing that. Already many rich people are able to travel the globe to access services such as sex-detection in countries abroad (since it’s illegal in India).

Through IVF they are able to select the best embryo candidates and screen out

embryos with markers for genetic abnormalities. Of course this isn’t a sure-shot solution, and it’s also not really “designer babies” (yet). In the US you can legally get IVF treatment and select whether you want to have a boy or a girl, along with screening out eggs that have the genetic markers for diseases – I guess we can all agree that it’s certainly unnatural, and definitely somewhat “designed” reproduction.

The cost for such IVF treatment at large and reputed clinics starts at \$25,000 and goes up to much, much more based on what you’re asking for. It’s rumoured that many rich people from across the globe, and especially celebrities use such facilities to ensure that they have “perfect families”.

The rich are always going to get a better class of options and care, but does this mean that because the rich might get perfect families, the poor shouldn’t get

life-saving genetic treatment? That’s like cutting off your nose to spite your face.

I think it’s time we stop being so upset by everything and realise that mother nature is like a casino – it may appear to lose a few hands and a few will get away with a few winnings, but in the end the house always wins, and casinos always make more money than they pay out.

It’s best we let nature decide who and what survives in the long run, and just get on with improving technology, our understanding of biology and extending the quality of our lives.

The one concession I do have to make, however, is admitting that the world would be a very boring place if everyone was genetically perfect and similar. I don’t want to hear the kind of music I’d make up, I want some mad genius to push the limits of music composition and wow me... for example.

LESSONS FROM FICTION

A SHORT LOOK AT HOW POPULAR FICTION HAS COVERED GENETIC ENGINEERING

BY ROBERT SOVEREIGN-SMITH

Fiction (especially science fiction), leads the way for us. It’s the best of us imagining a future, and sometimes that future is utopian, and then sometimes it’s horrifying. This is what helps us keep grounded in reality, and fiction plays an important role in us charting our way forward.

Here’s a look at some popular takes on genetic engineering and eugenics in fiction, in order to help us imagine what our world could be like. We’ll leave it to you to

make up your mind about whether genetic engineered humans are a good or bad idea. Remember to send your feedback to editor@digit.in because we really want to know whether you’re pro genetic engineering or against it.

2001: A SPACE ODYSSEY

Arthur C Clarke’s magnificent story is one that scratches the surface of what would later go on to become the idea of transhumanism. Being able to transcend all the drawbacks of being human, David Bowman is converted by alien technology

to an immortal intelligence that is able to transcend both space and time, yet remains as a protector of Earth. The story also reveals an interesting idea about how mankind evolved from apes. Read the book (or the whole Odyssey series), we prefer it to the movie.

RESIDENT EVIL

Although not really being genetically engineered in the positive direction, this game (and later movie franchise) explores how the typical evil corporation (Umbrella Corp) uses a genetically modified virus to